

of contrast and brightness to play with, from pitch black to really bright. The Philips 150s has a poor contrast ratio of 250:1, leaving little room for tweaking.

In the 17-inch models, the highest contrast ratio—550:1—was logged by the LG Flatron L1730S. It was followed by the BenQ and CMV at 500:1.

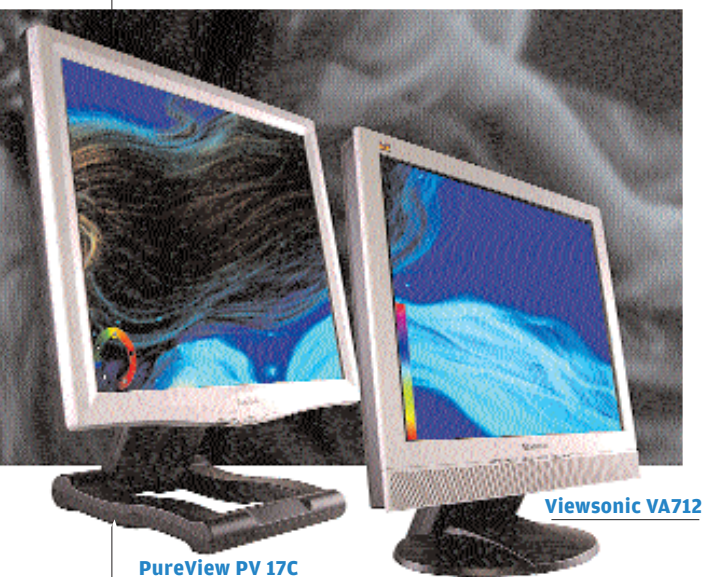
Dimensions

Tighter physical dimensions are always talked about when LCDs are compared with CRTs.

In the 15-inch category, the S-Media and BenQ boasted depths of just 12.8 and 13.6 cm respectively. This takes into account the base as well, and not just the panel. The ViewSonic VE510b had the smallest width and height of just 32.5 cm and 32.3 cm—it was a really neat package.

In the 17-inch category, the LG Flatron L1730S was sleek—it was just 11.5 cm deep, making it stand out from the rest. The NEC left enough space, width- and height-wise, to place it on a table under the file shelf and place stereo speakers on either side.

A higher contrast ratio means the user can set the monitor to display images with better visual depth



The Winsonic L17X, a new entrant in the LCD monitor segment, on the other hand, was comparatively very large—42.5 cm tall and 20.4 cm thick.

Weight

Monitors are not peripherals that see often changes in physical placement—weight, therefore, doesn't really matter that much. But of course, you'd always prefer a lighter monitor!



How We Tested

The monitors were tested keeping in mind performance, features, and value for money. Before running the tests, the monitors were placed perfectly vertical in order to eliminate any uniformity issues, and were auto-calibrated. All monitors were set to their native resolutions, and their drivers were loaded so we could get them to perform at their best.

The Test Bed Configuration: Both—the reference and test systems—were running on a P4 3.0 GHz CPU with 1 GB of DDR SDRAM, an nVidia 5950 Ultra graphics card, and a 7200 rpm SATA hard drive.

Features: In the Features tests, we looked for value-additions and other aspects that aimed at increasing the user-friendliness of the display. The features noted varied in significance—some were simple, like the user-friendliness of the OSD (On Screen Display); some were important, like power consumption, depth and weight.

One important thing we looked at was the monitor base, which decides the tilt the monitor is capable of—the more the better.

Some LCDs can be rotated vertically—landscape to portrait. This is useful while reading a long Word file or a PDF without the aid of a scroll-wheel mouse.

An oft-overlooked feature is the supplied user manual and quick start guide. It is especially helpful if the manual clearly states the full technical specifications of the monitor.

Performance: We used the DisplayMate benchmarking software to gauge the LCD monitor's performance. This software uses images to test a monitor for criteria such as Point Shape and Visibility. For example, to gauge how accurately the LCD can display a fine point, and whether or not it is able to retain the round shape of the dot, can be gauged by this test.

In the colour and greyscale set of tests, we checked for colour reproduction, the level shift problem, and the streaking or ghosting effect. We ran the 16-intensities and 64-level primary and secondary colour intensities tests to see how well the monitors could display shades.

In the miscellaneous tests within DisplayMate, we checked for screen uniformity. We also tested the Reverse Video Contrast.

The Pixel Persistence Test was run to check for jerks or image blurring. We used the Passmark Monitor Test to check for image persistence at the edges.

For the viewable angle test, we used a protractor placed inline with the LCD panel, and the screen was viewed from either side. A document containing different fonts was viewed from various angles, letting us determine the angles at which the text still looked sharp.

Price: We took the price of each monitor vis-à-vis its features and performance into account.

How we awarded

The features, performance and price scores were given relevant weightages, and an overall score out of 100 was calculated. The product that scored the highest was adjudged the winner of the *Digit* Best Buy Gold award for its category, while the second highest got the *Digit* Best Buy Silver award.

Of the 15-inch monitors, the CMV CT-529A was the lightest at just 2.6 kg, followed by the S-Media at 2.7 kg. The Philips 150s, at 5 kg, was the heaviest.

In the 17-inch segment, the CMV CT-712A was the lightest at 3.4 kg, followed by the Acer at 3.49 kg. The NEC LCD1770NXM is the heaviest, at 6.5 kg—which is very heavy by LCD standards.

Flexibility

If a monitor allows for height adjustment, you can set it to the level that makes for most comfortable viewing. And monitors that do not allow for height adjustment will require you to adjust the height of